

**Natural language and philosophical language.
Nationalism and Universalism in Leibniz's praise
of the German language**

**by
Olga Pombo**

Center for Philosophy of Science University of Lisbon

"What cannot be explained in popular terms is nothing
and should be exorcised from philosophy as by a kind
of purifying decanting"

Leibniz (GP 4: 143)

& 1. Presentation

French among the Germans, German among the French, Leibniz was a resolute supporter of the qualities of the German language, of the need to raise it to a higher degree of perfection, and of the urgency of teaching philosophy to speak in its mother tongue.

These theses - and the paradoxal nationalism that they are imbued with - constitute the root of the inspiring role Leibniz will play in the German linguistic thought of the 18th and 19th centuries. An impact that is partially explained by the fact that, contrary to what happened with most of Leibniz works – which, as we know, were unheard of and still today do not have a complete critic edition – the fundamental texts where the question of the German language is dealt with were of rapid public knowledge: the *Dissertatio de Stylo Philosophico Nizolii* was published by Leibniz in 1670, the

Unvorgreiffliche Gedancken by Eccard in 1717, one year after the death of Leibniz, and the *Nouveaux Essais* by Raspe in 1765.

With regard to the praise of the German language, Leibniz theses were incessantly taken by the German thought of later centuries. That is the case of Fichte who, in *Reden an Die Deutsche Nation* of 1808¹, uses arguments very similar to those of Leibniz, regarding German as the language that most closely approximates the primitive and original language and whose strength derives exactly from its proximity to the original sources (cf. 1808: 108-109). And Hegel - even if a strong critic of the leibnizian project for the constitution of an artificial philosophical language,² follows Leibniz praise of German as the best prepared language for philosophical work although locating that superiority in different roots. While Leibniz places this superiority in the concretion of German vocabulary and therefore in the relation of univocity that each word maintains with the fact or the object of people's concrete experience to which the word refers, Hegel argues conversely that it is by the plurivocity of meanings that each German word contains, by the speculative ambiguity of German's vocabulary (each term having, not only several, but even opposite meanings) that German's superiority is manifested.³

Also with regard to the conception of language as a popular creation, Leibniz influence was straight in Herder (1744-1835) and in W. Humboldt (1767-1835) and, through them, in all German romanticism and later linguistic thought inspired by them. In fact, both Herder and Humboldt took the relationship established by Leibniz between Language and People. However, beyond what the Leibnizian theses could allow, both Herder and Humboldt tended to underline the irreducible spiritual individuality of each people and each language.

¹ Cf., in particular discourses IV and V, respectively pp. 107-121 and 122-135.

² Cf. *Encyklopädie Der Philosophischen Wissenschaften Im Grundrisse*, the extensive note to § 459

³ About Leibniz and Hegel position towards German language, cf. COOK (1974) and also our study "Hegel and Language. Study in the form of Preface or Introduction", in POMBO (2010: 219-254).

Herder, in *Abhandlung über den Ursprung der Sprache*, of 1772, by fully identifying reason and language (cf. 1772: 80-81), and by understanding each language as a particular point of view of the world (cf. 1772: 144 ffs.), renounces to seek, behind the diversity of national languages, the universal structure of a mother tongue, in which he decisively departs from Leibniz commitment in the constitution of an *a posteriori* universal language, that is, a language based in the elements common to all natural languages.⁴ Also Humbolt in *Ueber das Vergleichende Sprachstudim im Beziehung auf die verschiedenen Epochen der Sprachentwickilung* of 1835, affirms the deep identity between the language and the so-called "spirit of the people" (cf., for example, 1835 § 10). However, to the extent that he conceives language, not as a particular perspective of the world (as Herder did), but as the echo of the universal nature of man,⁵ his posição, more than that of Herder, is truly Leibnizian⁶.

Besides being the inspirational root of these two great lines of posterior German linguistic thought, Leibniz is the greatest representative, in the 17th century, of a movement which - especially after Luther translation of the Bible⁷ - emerges in Germany aiming at strengthening national consciousness, unifying the several dialects and reforming German language. A movement in which are committed mostly scholars, clerics and educated officials who need a uniform language of chancellery to improve official communication between the approximately three hundred states that made up the Holy Roman

⁴ For a presentation of Leibniz work in this area, cf. POMBO (1997: 203-221). We know that, in the opposite direction to Leibniz project for the constitution of a *Rational Grammar*, Herder conceives the project of building a general physiognomy of nations based on a comparative analysis of their various languages.

⁵ Cf., for example, HUMBOLT (1835 § 4) where linguist's task is defined as the search for the "spiritual dynamism of humanity" or "internal universal cause" of language, underlying the different languages and linguistic groups.

⁶ As GADAMER (1976: 292) says, "it is in the monastic universe of Leibniz that [(Humbolt)] inscribes the diversity of language construction".

⁷ The translation, undertaken by Luther between 1523 and 1534, corresponds to a theological and evangelical imperative aimed at enabling communication of the Christian message to all social layers, including the people. Luther translation of the Bible was indeed decisive for the establishment of a common German language, above all, at the level of vocabulary able to recover popular linguistic traditions, everyday language terminology and to exclude latinizing artifices of scholars.

Empire. A movement too, that seeks to antagonize the great penetration of Latin in universities and of French in court and aristocracy.⁸ Leibniz is precisely a major representative of this movement as well as an inspiration for far-reaching practical measures. This is the case of the *Consultatio* written in 1676 for the establishment of a German Academy, Leibniz claims that all the works to be carried out by the future Academy should be written in German. And later, in the context of the Berlin Academy of Sciences that Leibniz actually founded in 1700 and of which he was first president, Leibniz demands that the study and defense of the German language should be included among the central objectives of the Academy.

& 2. German language in the *Dissertatio*, in the *Nouveaux Essais* and in the *Unvorgreifliche Gedancken*

Leibniz position on German language is for the first time presented in the *Dissertatio* - the *Dissertation of Stylo Philosophico Nizolli* - published by Leibniz in 1670.⁹ The general thesis there advocated is that German is the richest language in popular terms and therefore the best prepared for philosophical work. The argument is this: because, beyond elegance, philosophical discourse must seek above all truth and clarity; because, as Leibniz says, "the truth of a proposition can obviously be known only if the meaning of his words is known, that is ... if it is clear" (GP 4: 139), because "the greatest clarity lies in the use of vulgar terms that retain popular use" (GP 4: 145), philosophy must be cultivated in natural languages. As Leibniz says, "what cannot be explained in popular terms is nothing and should be exorcised from

⁸As BELAVAL says (1952: 27), "the cultivated public of the late seventeenth century forgot Spanish, still knew Italian, was going to start learning English, especially practised French – a true universal language along with Latin – but ignored German."

⁹ This is a famous preface entitled *Marii Nizolii of Veris Principiis Et Vera Ratione Philosophandi Against Pseudo-Philosophos* that Leibniz wrote to the second edition of a book published by the Italian humanist Marius Nizolius, entitled *From Veris Pincipiis Et Vera Ratione Philosophandi Against Pseudo-PhiLosophos*, published in 1553. For a detailed analysis of this text, cf., our study "Leibniz, Nizolius and philosophical style", in POMBO (2010: 175-192).

philosophy as by a kind of purifying decanting" (GP 4: 143). On the other hand, because German is the richest language in popular terms, no other language is better prepared than German for philosophical work. Because German is the most appropriate language for philosophical activity, Leibniz defends the thesis, of great later impact, according to which it is necessary to teach philosophy to speak German. As he says,

"[if] the exaggerated scholastic style of philosophy has gradually become obsolete in England and France (it is) because, there, people have long begun to cultivate philosophy in their own language (and if) in Germany scholastic philosophy is more firmly established (this is) because, among other reasons, one has only begun to philosophizing in German" (GP 4: 144).

Three important consequences can be deduced from here. On the one hand, the praise of German as a philosophical language for having an excellent repository of concrete terms corresponds to the ideal, so characteristically Leibnizian (it is also that inspires its projects of construção of a universal language), of language clarification. Being concrete, each term translates an immediate relationship with the reality signified thus avoiding the ambiguity and equivocity characteristic of abstract terms that, by definition, abstractly designate a quality or mode that really does not exist as such. On the other hand, Leibniz makes the vocabulary of the German language dependent on the practical and even mechanical activities of the German people which, in his view, more than any other, has cultivated for centuries the practical arts, especially the mechanics. A reason why, as Leibniz writes, "even the Turks use German names to designate metals in the mines of Greece and Asia" (GP 4: 144). In other words, Leibniz argues not only that there is a profound relationship between the language, the people and their civilization, but also that, above all, it is at the vocabulary level that this relationship is established. Finally, a third conclusion may be drawn from the analysis of this text. To the extent that it is in the use of popular terms that can reside, not only the clarity of philosophical discourse but, let us say, the touchstone that

distinguishes what is truly philosophical – what can be said in popular terms – and what is nothing but empty verbalism, we understand that the adoption of the German language as a philosophical language does not involve the progressive formalization of the natural language – which would imply the increasing use of technical terms – but concerns the respect and reuse of the potential meaning of people's terms which, as such, maintain an immediate and faithful relation to the real. It is therefore a question of gaining clarity, not by formalizing the natural language – which would require the introduction of the conceptual technical devices that Leibniz exactly intends to avoid – but by the reverse process, that is, by the deepening of its concreteness and naturalness, here understood as a primitive relationship of proximity between the vocabulary of the natural language and the objects and concrete actions of the world of men who created and use it.

In book III of the *Nouveaux Essais*, Leibniz returns to the superiority of German language. But, if in the text of youth that is the *Dissertatio* of 1670, Leibniz stressed that superiority through the structural analysis of his current vocabulary, now, in the *Nouveaux Essais*, written more than thirty years later, between 1703-1704, Leibniz explains in which consists that superiority according to a genetic point of view. Starting from the traditional theological thesis of a monogenesis of all languages, that is, the existence of a primitive adamic language, unique, perfect, natural, adequate, Leibniz claims that it is the German or the Teutonic that most closely approaches it. As he writes:

"if Hebrew and Arabic are closer to it (the primitive language) it must be very altered and it seems that *the Teutonic has conserved more of the natural and* (to speak the language of Jacob Boheme) *of the Adamic* (GP 5: 260).¹⁰

¹⁰ It should be noted that, with this thesis, Leibniz rejects the priority of Hebrew, usually considered by the great philologists of the sixteenth century (Postel, Bibliander, Benito Pereyra and Luther himself) as the mother tongue from which all the other languages would have been formed. Note also that the primitive character of German is here immediately assimilated to its natural and adamic character, concepts that, in Leibniz, tend to be identified. For further developments on Leibniz position on the adamic language, cf., COURTINE (1980), PIGEON (1997: 53- 61) and also the precious volume edited by DASCAL and YAKIRA (1993).

Indeed, the adamic language is for Leibniz fundamentally something that has been lost but which can be etymologically rediscovered, in the naturalness of their still remaining traces, in the phonic and articulatory expressiveness that is yet manifested in natural languages, especially in German.

It is precisely in this direction that the book III of the *Nouveaux Essais* goes on. After stating that the old German is the language that retains more of the natural and the adamic, Leibniz shows what this naturalness consists of, what is this "anything primitive" (NE. III,II, § 1, GP 5: 260) which, despite all the transformations suffered, the German retains up to now. Through a series of examples, Leibniz defends the onomatopoeic origin of many of the words of the German language and the phonetic symbolism of the letters that "by a natural instinct, the ancient Germans, Celts and other peoples related to them" (NE. III,II, § 1, GP 5: 261) used to mean a violent movement, or a sweet movement, or a small breath, or everything that is as if isolated in a kind of plain. That is, Leibniz finds out two fundamental types of naturalness: the onomatopoeic origin of the names, that is, the mimetic relationship between the name and what it means; and the phonic expressiveness of the letters, resulting from the primitively established agreement between sounds, affections and ideas. And, in both cases, German reveals its profound naturalness. German is therefore not the adamic language but it is, among all natural languages, the most primitive, the one that, in Leibniz eyes, retains a greater proximity to the biological and psychological (articulatory) origin of language. Its superiority lies, after all, in its antiquity, that is to say, in its naturalness, in its essential proximity to the language of Adam.

We may therefore state that there is an agreement, or better, a complementarity between Leibniz theses in the *Dissertatio* and in the *Nouveaux Essais*, on the superiority of German as a especially

adequate language for philosophical work. The concretion of the terms that, according to the *Dissertatio*, characterizes German still today, corresponds, in the *Nouveaux Essais*, to the natural relationship, primitively established, between the names and the realities signified, between the sounds, the objects and the concrete actions that they mimetically translate. Likewise, the appeal made in the *Dissertatio* for the use of a popular terminology, it is now translated in the *Nouveaux Essais* by the conviction of its originally popular root. Onomatopoeia and phonetic symbolism are processes perfectly within the reach of the popular man. They are even the result of the natural instinct of ancient Germans. At the same time, it is these processes that, at the root of the language naturalness, make it an instrument particularly suitable for the exercise of reason because these are the processes that guarantee, by their own presence, the fundamental agreement between the Nature and the Word.

Leibniz third main text on German language is the *Unvorgreiffliche Gedancken*, published by Eccard in 1717. Now, the objective is not so much the exaltation of the virtues of the German language – an exaltation which however is also present – but the need of its greatest improvement. As if, after having verified in the *Dissertatio* of 1660 the superiority of German and tried, in the *Nouveaux Essais*, to understand the origin and reason of its advantage, Leibniz wanted now to draw the attention of his contemporaries to the need of gathering efforts for elevating it to a superior state of perfection. A task that, according to Leibniz, involves two complementary movements, one of protection of its existing virtues, another of recognition and correction of its imperfections and defects which, for Leibniz, consist in the absence of terminology appropriate to the meaning of all realities that do not have an immediate relation to the sensitive. As Leibniz says, "one feels the imperfection of our language in things that, not being of the immediate *fora* of the senses, can only be understood through meditation and reflection" (UG § 2).

It is thus possible to say that if, in *the Dissertatio*, Leibniz praised German for its richness in concrete terms, a richness that in the *Nouveaux Essais* gets an etymological explanation, now, in the *Unvorgreiffliche Gedancken*, Leibniz makes the inverse path by regretting German's absence of abstract terms: "we lack terms to express the movements of the soul, certain virtues and crimes and various qualities of the soul whose use is frequent in morals and politics" (UG § 10). There is clearly a change of regime which, moreover, Leibniz himself is aware of. As Leibniz writes:

"we could easily console ourselves from the lack of logic and metaphysics terms. I praised, in another time and place, our language for it expresses nothing but real things (...). I then boasted with the Italians and the French that we, Germans, had for our thoughts a touchstone singular and unknown from other nations ... which was our own language, that what was clearly expressed in it, without resorting to imported and unusual words, was something real, that it did not admit any empty term of meaning and absolutely excluded all words expressing ideas that have no object." (UG § 11).

By highlighting this change, we do not intend to point out any contradiction in the Leibnizian position which, we believe, does not exist. On the one hand, because the existence of a concrete vocabulary does not imply the absence of an abstract vocabulary; on the other hand, because in the *Dissertatio*, with the praise of German for its concrete vocabulary and the complementary indication of the need to avoid the use of technical terms, what, we believe, Leibniz intended to point out was the absence, in the German language, of words empty of content, of those latinisms that, as we have seen, Leibniz condemns for his obscurity and voidness. Now, the abstract vocabulary which, in the *Unvorgreiffliche Gedancken*, Leibniz considers that German must strive to conquer, has nothing in common with the lack of object that characterizes the vain, obscure and pedantic word of these masters of dialectic and dispute then essentially targeted.

&3 Two onomaturgic figures: the wise man and the anonymous people

The important and significant change exists, we believe, but not there. What is new in the *Unvorgreiffliche Gedancken* is the way Leibniz perspectives his own position and that of his peers, shall we say, the position of the sage or philosopher, in relation to their language.

In the *Dissertatio* the sage appeared under two distinct figures. One is that of the philosopher who seeks clarity and who, for this purpose, uses the popular terminology of his language in which he finds an immediate relationship with the real. The other is that of the scholastic who run away from the clarity of popular terminology, taking refuge in obscurities of style that allow him to maintain the appearance of a confront of ideas, something which in fact he fears. In any case, the philosopher is not responsible for a direct intervention in determining the qualities of the language. This is entirely a popular creation.

Now, in the *Unvorgreiffliche Gedancken* the situation is diverse. Now, in the German language, Leibniz diagnoses a deficiency, a lack, precisely that which derives from the non-intervention of the sage in determining the quality of the language. As he writes: "the sages, solely occupied with their Latin, have almost entirely abandoned their tongue to the people who, following only their instinct, never failed to elevate it to a high degree of perfection" (UG § 9). Leibniz presents afterwards several proposals and suggestions for the implementation of this enrichment. It can even be said that the text as a whole has no other purpose. We will see that it is up to the sage or wise man to carry out all these improvements.

Fundamentally, Leibniz proposes three measures: 1) to recover and restore old and terms fallen out of favor; 2) to import and adapt foreign terms; 3) to invent new terms. Regarding the first measure - recovery and re-establishment of old and terms fallen in disuse - Leibniz advises

to start by reviewing and examining all the words, both those relating to the various arts and professions, and those used in the countryside, in the city and in the various regions of Germany and related peoples (Bavarians, Austrians, Suavs, etc.) as well as all the forgotten or out-of-use terms and those who, being originally Germans, are now used in other nations (cf. UG § 32)¹¹. The second measure for improving the German language concerns the import and adaptation of foreign terms. "It is not in a language, I think, that we should rise up in puritans and intending, for a superstitious fear, to run away, as if it were a mortal sin, of every foreign term" (UG § 16). However, for Leibniz, if excessive puritanism is to be condemned, it is also necessary to avoid the opposite extreme, a situation, such as that which was then lived in Germany, of massive and indiscriminate entry of foreign terms that have tampered with the language. If such a situation is reprehensible to all titles, it does not justify, according to Leibniz, the drastic prohibition, advocated by some, of the use of any foreign term. It is necessary to be prudent and moderate, to receive and adapt, in a smaller number of cases and only when this is indispensable. Preferably, it is necessary to choose terms taken from languages close to German. As for the third proposal – the invention of new terms – Leibniz considers that one should seek to obey the law of similarity: "it is not only permissible but very commendable to forge new terms provided that this similarity is observed as much as possible, as long as we move as little as possible away from the use already established, that their sound is pleasant to the ear and that there is little difficulty in pronouncing them" (UG § 75).

However, any of these three language improvement measures involves a type of task that only the wise can perform. Leibniz is fully aware of this. As far as the construction of new terms is concerned, it is

¹¹ For this inventory, Leibniz suggests that the old German books and archives should be searched as well as it should be done a review of the literature and look for unusual terms (UG §§ 29, 65-66). That work is foreseen to be embodied in three major works: the *Dictionary or Lexicon*, containing the words in use, the *Language Treasure or Cornucopia*, with the words relating to the various arts and crafts and the *Language Source or Glossari* which would collect the old words and lead to the discovery of etymologies (UG C 33)

not only necessary to know the phonic and phonological laws that regulate the system of the natural language, but also, says Leibniz, the support of some illustrious men who, with their authority, venerate and confirm these terms and their use. For the new terms to be profitably used it is necessary to "have them examined by knowledgeable judges who, by their authority and example, put them into vogue" (UG § 76). As for the importation and adaptation of foreign terms, although there is no explicit reference in Leibniz, it involves by definition a set of powers that cannot be attributed to that anonymous entity that is the people, inextricably linked to the very language that gives it its identity. Finally, with regard to the recovery and re-establishment of old and terms fallen in disuse, Leibniz even advises that, when choosing employees, one should take into account the specificity of the various tasks. Thus, for example, for the constitution of the etymological dictionary are necessary:

"men who are solidly wise in natural physics, particularly in botany, chemistry, knowledge of the various parts of animals, mathematics, in different parts of architecture, crafts, manufactures, commerce, navigation, knowledge of metallics and hermetics and other things of nature; and since each of these scholars cannot have in particular all the sciences set out above in a sufficiently high degree, all together must often compare their own ideas" (UG § 52).

We see, therefore, that in the *Unvorgreifliche Gedancken*, if the German, at its origin, continues to be thought of as a popular creation, its improvement now requires the development of a series of artificial processes that can only be carried out by a set of scholars with diverse interests and competences. What is now new is not only the very need for improvement, already enlightening, but also the determination of the entity to be held responsible for it. If the German language needs to be perfected, it is because, on the one hand, the set of qualities with which, initially, as a popular creation, it was endorsed, proved to be insufficient face to the progress of knowledge and the demands of rigour placed by the new sciences; and because, on the other hand, the scholars, exactly those who are responsible by that progress,

abandoned their language, passed it over in favor of erudite the but dead languages, because detached from any popular language.

Thus, it is to the sage or wise men, the main interested in overcoming these imperfections, to replace the people in the work of determining the qualities of the language, developing and refining their virtualities and introducing new perfections. It is as if, having left perfect the hands of the people, anonymous onomaturgos entirely responsible for its origin, this would later come to lose his capacity for intervention, determination and control over his work. Having not any responsibility, neither in the progressive inadequacy of the language to the new realities created by science, nor in its adulteration, the popular onomaturgos cannot now be required to prolong the performance of his functions, to correct what has come out of his hands, to perfect and introduce improvements that, in fact, he does not feel necessary.

The function of the wise man will therefore be understood otherwise by Leibniz. In *the Dissertatio*, the sage was supposed to do no more than using his natural language in whose qualities (for the determination of which he had contributed nothing) he would nevertheless find the background of "reality" that guaranteed the clarity and meaning of his own discourse. Now, according to the *Unvorgreifliche Gedancken*, it is up to him to promote the improvement of his language. However, to the extent that this improvement is thought out, not only as the preservation of the original purity of the language but also the introduction of new terms, we can say that, through the figure of the sage that the *Unvorgreifliche Gedancken* design, Leibniz recovers, for himself and for his peers, the role of the onomaturgos which, in the *Dissertatio* and also in the *Nouveaux Essais*, was entirely delivered in the hands of the anonymous people.

The wise men is therefore an onomaturgic figure with very peculiar characteristics. Unlike Plato's onomaturgos, the wise man of the *Unvorgreifliche Gedancken* does not operate from the

contemplation (as an intuition not yet linguistically mediated) of the reality of the objects to be named, as it is supposed to have been the proper acting of the popular onomaturgos. The sage of the *Unvorgreifliche Gedancken* has, at his disposal, an already linguistic raw material – the natural language – and it is from it, from the recovery of his past, from the respect by his own rules and limits, that he can build "more language" and, with it, to think better the new reality that he himself helped to discover. On the other hand, like Plato's onomaturgos, the sage operates rationally, with full control and awareness of the variables at stake and not already in the unconscious, "instinctive", way that characterized the onomaturgic activity of the ancient Germans.

It remains to be said that these two onomaturgic figures, the wise man and the anonymous people, are not contradictory, but complementary. With the popular, unconscious, instinctive, anonymous onomaturgy, Leibniz frees the explanation of the origin of the language of intellectualist temptation and its aporias.¹² With the onomaturgy of the sage, Leibniz safeguards the already linguistic nature of the knowledge of the real and, at the same time, the rational character, not of the origin of language, but of its improvement. It is because the sage had the possibility, through natural language, to build new scientific realities, that now he can forge, for these same realities, a more appropriate and rigorous terminology.

This complementarity is also reflected in the retroactive movement that the work of perfecting the language carried out by the sage is supposed to exercise on the intellectual development of its people. As

¹² At the end of the dialogue *Cratylus* it is Socrates who directly puts the paradox to which Cratylus position leads by asking how it would be possible that the onomaturgos, without the help of the primitive names, not yet established, how could he know the things (whose nature the names should later translate) that only through the names can be known (cf. *Cratylus*, 437 and 438c). It is exactly from that paradoxal situation, wonderfully denounced by Socrates, that Plato will withdraw the astonishing final consideration with which the dialogue ends showing how it is not in words but beyond them, in the opening of thought to the contemplation of the true objects – the immutable forms – that one can aspire to know the truth (cf. *Cratylus*, 439a and followings).

Leibniz says in the first lines with which he begins this important text - *Unvorgreiffliche Gedancken* - which we have been commenting, since language is the "mirror of understanding" (UG § 1),¹³ "the nations that seek to cultivate their understanding apply to the perfection of their language" (UG § 1). Because it is by improving the language that the nation's understanding can be elevated, it is that the action of the sage over the language can contribute decisively to the intellectual formation of its people.

It is worth calling attention to the paradoxical nature of this apparent Leibniz nationalism. If we realize that the improvement of the German proposed by Leibniz is not only done by deepening its roots and qualities – national characteristics that define the unique and superior profile of the German vis-à-vis other languages – but also implies the introduction of external elements, coming from other languages and other peoples, elements to which only the confrontation of nationalities and cultures can allow access, we see that, underlying the nationalism of the author who conceived the most consequential and significant projects of construction of a universal language of all time, is hidden an undisguised universalist vocation.¹⁴

¹³ "Ein Spiegel Der Verstandes", UG § 1. For an analysis of the mirror metaphor present in the *Unvorgreiffliche Gedancken* (this metaphor also appears in other texts, cf. for example, *Nouveaux Essais* III, VII, § 6) cf. DASCAL (1976 : 204-5). It is precisely because that metaphor appears in the *Unvorgreiffliche Gedancken* that Dascal interprets it as pointing to a non-external relationship of language and thought. According to Dascal, that metaphor does not mean that language and thought are seen by Leibniz as maintaining a relationship neither of exteriority, nor of mere influence of thought on language (of which language would be the mirror of thought) but also implies the thesis of a real influence of language on thought because, otherwise, it would be impossible to explain its use in a text with the characteristics and purposes of *Unvorgreiffliche Gedancken*.

¹⁴ For a different interpretation, cf. WALKER (1972) who argues that the *Unvorgreiffliche Gedancken* show a level of nationalism and patriotism that is surprising in a figure like Leibniz, however recognizing that, face to the excesses of some of its contemporary, for example Meier, Leibniz's position is up to moderate (WALKER 1972: 303-4). On the close connection established by Leibniz between the intellectual liberation of the German people and their ability to think and speak in their mother tongue, cf. COOK (1974: 97 Secs).

If it is through the drawing the figure of the popular onomaturgos that the later influence of Leibniz linguistic reflection is most felt, it is nevertheless on the figure of the enlightened onomaturgos presented in the *Unvorgreiffliche Gedancken* that the deepest intention underlying the Leibnizian project of construction of a universal language is best hidden (and present) as well as the role that Leibniz reserves for him self as its logo and onomaturgic creator.

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